monkey chieftains, Vali and Sugriva, Rama intervened to kill the former. It was, of course, Vali's destiny to meet his end by divine hands and his own personal conduct was clearly not above reproach.

But the episode and its consequences offer important insights into undertaking larger operations. Viewed from a power perspective, Rama favoured the lesser entity, the younger brother Sugriva, who was earlier ousted from his position. Common sense indicates that the weaker side is always more welcoming of intervention and even more inclined to tie its fortunes on a lasting basis. Having gained the services of Sugriva, it was farseeing of Rama to maintain the unity of the *vanara*s by taking Vali's son, Angada, under his personal protection. Inspiring his allies to act with alacrity was no easy task either. Predictably, Sugriva went back to a good life in Kishkinda after assuming the throne, and it required Lakshmana's anger to remind him of his obligations.

The entire period when the *vanara* sena (army) is sent in multiple directions is also an experience of strategic patience for Rama and Lakshmana. The coalition must not just assemble but be given time to do its work, often at the speed of its less efficient components. Sometimes, partners may not be able to deliver in time. That was the case for Rama later on with Pratardana, the king of Kashi, whose promised legions did not arrive in time to join the battle in Lanka. But it is to Rama's credit that he publicly acknowledged their intent. In life, there is always a next time and diplomacy must never foreclose possibilities.

THE PAST AND THE FUTURE

As it goes about its business of rising in the international order, India has to bear in mind that the world is continuously changing, as indeed are its ties with various players. In the early years after Independence, we sought to build a relationship with the West while creating our decisional space. At the same time, constituencies in the developing world were nurtured by building on the obvious empathy of post-colonialism. Cooperation with the Socialist bloc was explored, with tangible outcomes in the economic and security spheres. As the pressures of the Cold War grew and Sino-US rapprochement unfolded, it compelled India to double down on its Soviet relationship. A large part of its difficulties with the West emanated from the preference that the latter showed for a military-ruled Pakistan.

It was, therefore, natural that the end of the Cold War would lead to readjustments on India's part and of the world towards India. These processes have gained steady momentum in the quarter of the century that has passed. Their consolidation has been facilitated by the fact that in the last decade, New Delhi has shed much of the ideological baggage of the past. The US, in particular, is seen much more as part of the solution than of